



Preliminary investigation update

Grounding on Boolarong Bank, Weerona Channel, Kanooka Heads -
Preliminary investigation update

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INVESTIGATION WORKFLOW SUITE

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Preliminary update - the information in this report is based on the evidence available at the time of writing and may change as the investigation proceeds.

At 18:12:04 on 07/07/2026, ferry MV Tarrakin Star, inbound on TF18 in darkness with 38 passengers and three crew, left the Weerona Channel at Kanooka Heads, grounding on Boolarong Bank.

Injuries were minor: one passenger reported a grazed shin and two were treated for distress. The starboard hull split and flooded, and the propeller, shaft, rudder stock and skeg were damaged. The vessel was withdrawn and the channel closed to commercial traffic for 19 hours.

The investigation is examining No. 4 beacon visibility from the northern approach, why the last service ran in darkness, the lack of chart plotter loss guidance, and reporting of the plotter's freeze.

The beacon-screening mangroves have been trimmed and a reduced-range notice issued. Two further investigation requests remain open.

What we know

MV Tarrakin Star is a 24.4 m aluminium catamaran passenger ferry certificated for 96 passengers. On 07/07/2026 it was operating the Kanooka Heads services. The masters changed over at the town wharf at about 13:05. The outgoing master told the relieving master that the chart plotter (electronic chart display) had frozen twice that morning and had recovered by itself both times. The plotter's event log records those freezes at 10:42 and 11:17. Neither master entered the fault in the defect book.

Service TF18, the last of the day, departed Muntari Island at 17:35. On board were 38 passengers, a master, a deckhand and a kiosk attendant. Civil twilight had ended at 17:29. The winter timetable's evening returns had been made in darkness since 01/06/2026.

The vessel entered the Weerona Channel from the north at 18:03:58. At about 18:04 the master sent the deckhand from the bridge to collect fares. At 18:05:30 the vessel was on the charted centreline abeam the No. 2 beacon, making 8.4 kt. At 18:07:06 the plotter display froze and, unlike that morning, did not recover. The master continued on visual reference and began looking for the No. 4 beacon at 18:08:31.

From 18:07:06 the recorded heading increased from 195 to 200 degrees and was then held, and the vessel moved progressively west. It crossed the channel's western edge at about 18:09. The master sighted the No. 4 beacon at 18:10:02, by which time the vessel was outside the dredged channel. The engine and steering data recorded no faults during the transit.

The echo sounder's shallow alarm, set at 0.9 m under the keel, sounded at 18:11:48. Both engines were put astern four seconds later. At 18:12:04 the vessel struck Boolarong Bank at 6.8 kt and stopped within 11 m on a falling tide. The contact point was 74 m west of the charted centreline and 54 m outside the dredged channel. The occurrence notification records the vessel heeled 4 degrees to starboard. The master's radio call described it as upright.

At 18:13:04 the master made a pan pan (urgency) call to Kanooka Heads Port Control. He stated he was not attempting to refloat and requested the port workboat. All passengers were in lifejackets by about 18:22. Issue in the forward saloon was slowed because that locker sits behind the kiosk counter. The workboat came alongside at 18:41 and the last passenger was ashore at 19:26.

No one was seriously injured. One passenger reported a grazed shin and two were treated at the wharf for distress. The starboard hull was split in way of the No. 2 void. That void had flooded to approximately 260 mm when the vessel refloated at 00:20 on 08/07/2026. The starboard propeller, shaft and rudder stock were damaged and the starboard skeg was torn away. The vessel was withdrawn from service and the channel was closed to commercial traffic for 19 hours.

What we are looking at

1. **The No. 4 beacon.** This covers whether the beacon could be seen from the northern approach, the 11/2025 solar conversion that reduced its rated range, how that change was passed on to channel users, and the repeated deferral of mangrove clearing on Weerona Islet. The operator's passage plan named this beacon as the secondary means of fixing position. Whether new foreshore floodlighting behind the beacon affected the master's ability to pick it up remains open.
2. **The rules for the channel's beacons.** WAN-2 section 4 and the services agreement between Kanooka Shire Council and Kanooka Heads Port Authority set any duty to measure the beacons, record their availability, or tell users of a change. These duties do not apply to the Weerona Channel because it is not a declared shipping channel.
3. **How the last service came to run in darkness.** Change approval CHG-2026-014 is being compared against route risk assessment RRA-07, which restricts the channel to daylight transits unless a specific night passage plan is approved. TF18 had run 31 times in darkness before the occurrence.
4. **Passage planning and plotter failure.** OPS-3 and its Weerona Channel appendix name the plotter as the primary means of fixing position but contain no night plan and no hold or abort point. The practice of the deckhand leaving the bridge to collect fares is also being examined.
5. **The plotter fault and its reporting.** This covers why the display froze, with cause code 0x51 linked to unapplied manufacturer firmware issued in 11/2024, and why the morning's freezes were passed on verbally under OPS-9 but not written in the defect book.
6. **Final warnings and passenger safety equipment.** This covers the echo sounder's 0.9 m shallow alarm setting against the 92 m crash-stop distance from 8 kt, and the forward saloon lifejacket locker's position behind a counter fitted in a 2019 refit. Questions about the same counter on the operator's two other 24 m vessels are with the operator and the state regulator.

Containment and next steps

Interim actions

- On 08/07/2026 the General Manager Operations suspended evening Muntari services. [NOT ESTABLISHED: whether the suspension remains in place.]
- On 22/07/2026 the Aids to Navigation Officer, Kanooka Shire Council, issued local notice to waterway users LNM-2026-14. The notice gives the No. 4 beacon's solar conversion and its 3 M nominal range. The Port Authority's aids to navigation register has been made available to every commercial operator using the channel. Tarrakin Ferries has reissued its Weerona Channel passage plan appendix as issue 3 with the corrected range. This action is still being implemented.
- Work order WO-176 was funded from the 2026 waterways contingency, under the Harbour Master, Kanooka Heads. The Weerona Islet canopy was trimmed to 2 m on 24/07/2026. A three-yearly trimming cycle has been programmed and the sightline re-measured from the inbound track on completion. This action is complete.
- The investigation has asked Tarrakin Ferries to write a night passage plan for the Weerona Channel, naming a hold point, before any further darkness transit. It has also asked that the services agreement's 50 m vegetation scope be replaced with a sightline test. Responses to both were due by 30/09/2026 and both remain open.

Next steps

The investigation is still examining why the plotter display froze, through the firmware and the maintenance chain. It is awaiting answers from the operator and the state regulator on the kiosk counter fitted to the two other 24 m vessels. The foreshore floodlighting question remains open. The Operations Manager's account of the change approval has been given verbally and has not yet been taken in a formal interview. The draft report will be reviewed by someone outside the investigation, and the parties will be given the chance to correct matters of fact. The final report is expected [NOT ESTABLISHED: expected date of the final report].

Distribution

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